

Smart phone, anyone?

Q. How do you know when a device has achieved 'smart' status?

A. When it has a 'reset' function, and an officially accepted security flaw.

Over the last couple of months, a slew of small, startling announcements add up to a clear turning point for the still humble mobile phone. For one, almost every phone manufacturer with Bluetooth-enabled phones has at least one model that gives total strangers around you, complete access to your phonebook and data. On some GPRS-enabled phones, they may even get free Web access using your account.

Until recently, a smart phone was simply one that incorporated PDA-like features. Now, they are busy pulling the ground from under the PDA scene, and aiming for bigger.

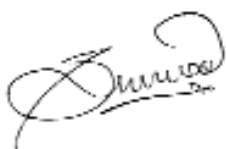
One sign of the impending transformation is that computing resources and battery power are available aplenty. Nokia announced upcoming support for Perl and Python scripting languages on their latest models. Scripting languages are resource hogs, but can be used to put together applications much more easily than is possible with more traditional tools, and can be credited for making the Web the accessible dynamic entity it is now.

Snake is passé, with a slew of adventure and strategy games being readied for the serious gamer. Now, both ATi and nVidia have announced graphics accelerators for pocket rockets. Pretty 3D effects and snappy graphics on 640 x 480 resolution colour screens will define the next frontier in mobile entertainment.

And now, for something serious—Toshiba has announced a new 2 GB hard disk, slightly more than 2 cm wide. That's two gigabytes of data storage, enough to comfortably carry an entire My Documents folder in a standard phone body. This, more than anything else, pushes the smart phone into a new league. You can actually carry around a useful amount of your work, and put all that processing power to good use.

But, for a little reminder of reality, the most exciting new feature for phones in the US is 'Push To Talk': A walkie-talkie-like service, which connects you—instantly—to any individual, or a closed group, without the hassles of dialing and waiting for a call to go through.

However, for all the fancy features, smart phones are still communication devices, and permanently busy phone networks the great leveler.



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